

Army MARS Training Bulletin

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The purpose of this bulletin is to clarify best practices following COMEX 21-2 in respect to sending messages by voice. This paper will present the problem, discuss considerations, and apply a solution.

The Problem:

The following is an example of a USMTF message sent by voice that represents an actual message received at HQ in 21-2. It is not the actual message. Region 1 is used in the example simply because the number 1 is first.

```
MSGID/COMSPOT/REGION ONE RJMOG//  
COMEV/ACTIVATION/041514Z/041514Z/REGION NET//  
LOCN/FEMA R1/US/12R//  
RMKS/1. FREQ: M999  
2. STATIONS: Joint Operations Officer AAA1AA, Joint Plans Officer AAA1BB,  
Joint AAA1CC  
3. REMARKS: The starting frequency was bad. Changed to M999.//
```

Sending this message through multi-layer networks caused unnecessary fatigue on the radio operators who processed the message through the enterprise. The factor of fatigue is relevant, as fatigue is a significant cause of human error.

Discussion:

The message presented above has problems that must be address before sending by voice:

- 1) It contains redundant or unnecessary information. For instance, the frequency information is presented twice. The call signs and joint billets of each station in the net is nice to know administratively in the RJMOG, but is operationally irrelevant at the HQ.
- 2) The XML like text format, with its “slashes and dashes” is not intended for voice transmission and unnecessarily arduous to verbalize. Do not send messages by voice in this format.
- 3) Voice templates for all USMTF messages exist, but the full library of these templates is not releasable. FM 6-99 has most of the voice templates and is releasable; however, COMSPOT is not one of the messages included in FM6-99.

We could release to MARS every USMTF voice template that MARS would commonly use, but doing so would avoid exercising problem solving skills. The COMSPOT is a good example MARS can use to apply the solution presented here.

Solution:

If the voice template exists in FM 6-99 the solution is simple: Use the voice template.

If the voice template does not exist in FM6-99, then the originating station must apply problem solving skills to create an ad-hoc voice template. This starts with:

- 1) Understanding the intent of voice message procedure is not to produce a facsimile of the text, rather to convey facts. Unfortunately, MARS has trained for decades the intent is to relate a facsimile of the text. Review the voice message templates in FM6-99, relate them to their USMTF text counterparts, and note that the voice templates is simply a way to organize and verbalize the most cognizant facts.
- 2) Revealing that some things in FM 6-99 templates are always the same. For instance, the first line is always the day time, the second line is always the unit.
- 3) FM 6-99 allows the choice of doing Line Numbers or Headings. For instance we say “Line Two” or “Unit”, but not both. Usually the line numbers are easier to verbalize. When we have to create an ad-hoc voice template for a text USMTF we cannot use line numbers because they are meaningless to the destination station. Therefore; we must use the header names. The USMTF text message has a header names for each field, refer to the MSC Message Creator Data Input tab.
- 4) Only use the fields that contain unique, relevant data. Don’t send blanks – just skip them.

For example:

COMSPOT	
Time	Zero Four One Five Three Zero Zulu
Unit	Alpha Main
Event	Activation
Event Time	Zero Four One Five One Four Zulu
Circuit Name	Region Net
Location	Region One
Frequency	Mike Niner Niner Niner

Note that usually it is unnecessary to say the full date time group, just the day as the month and year are understood. If a message being received on the first day of the month has a day of 31, it is clearly understood that was the last day of the previous month (yesterday). The receiving station simply fills in the month, year even though it is not verbalized.

Tasks to Trainers

- 1) Reverse traditional MARS training, or un-train, the notion that voice message procedure verbalizes a facsimile of text. Ensure Auxiliarists demonstrate sending facts using voice message templates.
- 2) Present opportunities for Auxiliarists to demonstrate the problem solving technique described here using USMTF COMSPOT as an example. Provide the Auxiliarists feedback until broad understanding is demonstrated.
- 3) Have Auxiliarists practice converting USMTF text to Voice Message Templates and back to USMTF text with 100% accuracy.